earlier. They said they wanted to atone for their sins – they wanted to do penance. Also they appeared to have got rid of their frustrations and tensions and were certainly more relaxed. Maybe they had learned to think good.

So very convinced was Kiran about the benefits of the meditation course that a permanent ward was created so that prisoners could undergo *Vipassana* courses throughout the year. And the facility was extended to the women prisoners also.

While talking to the inmates, one was left totally amazed at the almost miraculous effect this meditation has had on them. A very remarkable change in attitude was shown by T. P. Singh, who has spent more than nine-and-a-half years of his sentence on the charge of murdering his brother-in-law. He claimed that he was framed by his own parents with whom he had had a lot of differences: 'For nine years I kept the fire of revenge smouldering within me. My parents did not come to see me, not for one day throughout this period. But now I have written to them and requested them to visit me just once. I honestly want to touch their feet and thank them for sending me here because that was the way fated for me to meet my Guru. I hold nothing against them today except a sense of gratitude.'

Young Bashir was a Kashmiri doing time under the NDPS Act. He too claimed that he was framed by an influential Kashmiri trader from whom he had sought payment of his dues. During his incarceration his child-daughter died and he was refused permission to attend her funeral. That had made him very bitter, he stated. He revealed that he used to always remain worked up and tense and thus could not ever go to sleep before 1 a.m. or 2 a.m. Then during the fourth day of the meditation course, he was absolutely amazed to suddenly realize that for the past two days he had been invariably fast asleep by about 9 p.m. and would wake up much refreshed at 4 a.m. As he himself disclosed:

> My problem had always been not being able to achieve peace of mind or peace of heart. I had even written to my mother that she should forget that I ever existed. Even if I came out of prison I would still be no better off for my own house would also be a prison to me. One day I heard some prisoners talking about this thing called *Vipassana*. The first thing that came to my mind was that this was some sort of Hindu indoctrination. Even though I am a Muslim I decided to give it a try. During the course I realized that it had nothing to do with religion nor could one's faith be a barrier to it. It was just a way to learn how to refine your conduct and your thinking. Today I think I have found myself. I am at peace with my mind and my heart. Am I in jail? I ask myself. I look around and my senses tell me yes, but my heart says no. Today I am free.

Subhash, an inmate of Jail 4, adopted a more philosophical approach towards the changes that had taken place in him:

> I learnt that all those things that make life difficult for us do not lie outside of us. They are all within – be it anger, jealousy, lust, greed, revenge or such like. This was what we would have to discover and then wash away. During the past four years I have spent here I would always be planning revenge on those because of whom I landed here. But now I realize that it was no one's fault. It was all because of my own feelings; had I not been like I was I would not have done what I did. I realize my feelings now. And it's as if the bitterness and the anger have been washed away. I am determined now to cleanse myself of all the evil within me. The way I feel today I cannot see myself committing any crime ever.